

What Professional Identity Means in the Digital Age

What You'll Learn

- What "professional identity" actually means (and what it doesn't)
- What "digital reputation" is, and how it's different from professional identity
- How to tell the difference between a *claim* and *evidence*
- How to take a basic, private look at your own current online footprint
- How to name real evidence you already have from projects you've built

Why It Matters

Right now, you already have skills — things you've built, bugs you've fixed, ideas you've turned into working code. But if a stranger looked you up online today, would they be able to tell? Most people's online presence is accidental: old posts, unfinished profiles, nothing that shows what they can actually do.

This course is about fixing that on purpose. Over the next few lessons you'll turn your real Lumexa projects into a portfolio site, a brand kit, and case studies that actually show your skill. But before you build any of that, you need to understand what you're building *toward* — that's what today is for.

Where this fits: this course follows a path — **Identity** → **Services** → **Clients** → **Professional Presence** → **Opportunities**. Today is Identity, step one. We are not talking about freelancing, getting hired, or job platforms yet. Today is just about understanding yourself and what you've already got.

The Simple Version

Professional identity = the answer to: *"If a stranger saw only what I've made, what would they think I'm capable of?"*

It's not about sounding fake, corporate, or "adult." It's about being **clear and backed up by real evidence**. A 16-year-old's professional identity should still sound like a 16-year-old — just one who can back up what they say.

Digital reputation = everything that's already out there about you online, whether you built it on purpose or not. Some of it you control (a GitHub profile, a project page). Some of it just happened (an old comment, a forgotten social post, nothing at all).

Think of it like a game profile: your rank and match history show other players what you can actually do — not what you claim you can do. Professional identity works the same way, except your "stats" are your real projects.

Claim vs. Evidence — the most important idea in this lesson

This is a claim	This is evidence
"I'm good at JavaScript."	A link to a working project you coded in JavaScript.
"I can build websites."	A live site you deployed on Vercel.
"I care about clean design."	A Canva brand kit or a well-designed project page.
"I helped my team solve a bug."	A specific description of the bug and what you actually did to fix it.

Anyone can make a claim. Evidence is what makes people believe you — and it's what the rest of this course helps you build.

Worked Example (Fictional Persona)

Note: "Jordan R." below is a completely fictional example created for this lesson. Not a real student.

Jordan R., age 16, has been coding on Lumexa for about eight months. If you searched "Jordan R." online today, here's roughly what you'd find:

- A GitHub profile with two repositories — one has a clear README explaining what it does and why; the other is unfinished with no description.
- A page from a school robotics club listing Jordan as a member.
- An old social media post from two years ago, unrelated to coding.
- A finished Lumexa project: a simple weather app with a working interface.

What a stranger would conclude: Jordan has real technical ability (the weather app and the documented repo prove it), but the picture is inconsistent — the undocumented repo and the unrelated old post don't help, and there's no single place that pulls the good evidence together.

The fix (which is exactly what this course teaches): Jordan doesn't need to invent new achievements. Jordan needs to (1) finish documenting what already exists, (2) put the best evidence in one place, and (3) decide what story that evidence should tell. That's professional identity — arranging real evidence on purpose instead of leaving it scattered.

In-Class Activity: Digital Identity Audit

You'll fill out the **Digital Identity Audit worksheet** (shared by your instructor). Here's how it works:

Option A — If you already have some online footprint

1. Privately (not out loud, not in group chat), think through or briefly search what currently exists about you online: social profiles, GitHub, school pages, anything else.
2. Fill in the worksheet's footprint inventory table with what you find — you will **not** be asked to share this list with the class.
3. Note anything that feels like a gap or a risk (e.g., "nothing shows my coding work" or "an old post I wouldn't want a stranger to see first").
4. Complete the rest of the worksheet (see below).

Option B — If you don't have much or any online footprint yet

This is completely normal, especially if you're newer to Lumexa or don't have social media. Instead: 1. Skip the search step entirely. 2. In the footprint inventory table, write "No significant footprint yet" — that's a valid, honest answer. 3. Focus your energy on the rest of the worksheet: the 3 things you want people to know about you, and the 3 pieces of evidence you already have from your own work (Lumexa projects count!).

Either way, **you will never be asked to read your search results or personal profiles aloud to the class.** This activity is private and self-paced.

Key Terms Glossary

Term	Definition
Professional identity	The intentional, evidence-backed picture of your skills and work that others can see.
Digital reputation	Everything that currently exists about you online, whether you built it on purpose or not.
Personal brand	The consistent way you present your identity — your voice, visuals, and the story your evidence tells together.
Portfolio	A collection of your real projects, organized to show your skills clearly.
Credibility	The degree to which someone can trust that what you say about yourself is true.
Evidence vs. claim	A claim is a statement about yourself; evidence is proof — something someone else can look at and verify.

Knowledge Check

1. In your own words, what is the difference between "professional identity" and "digital reputation"?
2. Give one example of a *claim* and rewrite it as *evidence*.
3. True or false: having little to no online footprint at your age is a sign you're behind. Explain your answer.
4. Why does this course avoid the words "fake" or "corporate" when describing professional identity? What should it mean instead?

5. Name one real project or piece of work you've done that could count as evidence of a skill.

Reflection Prompts

1. If a stranger looked up your name today, what's one thing you'd want them to *not* be the first thing they see — and why?
 2. Of the things you've built so far (on Lumexa or elsewhere), which one are you proudest of, and what does it actually prove about your skill?
 3. What's one word you want your future professional identity to make people think of when they see your work?
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Submission Instructions

- Complete the **Digital Identity Audit worksheet** in full.
- Submit it using the method your instructor shares at the end of class (Google Doc link or LMS upload).
- Do not include anyone else's personal information (friends, classmates, family) in your worksheet.
- Bring your completed worksheet to Lesson 2 — you'll use it directly to start building your portfolio.